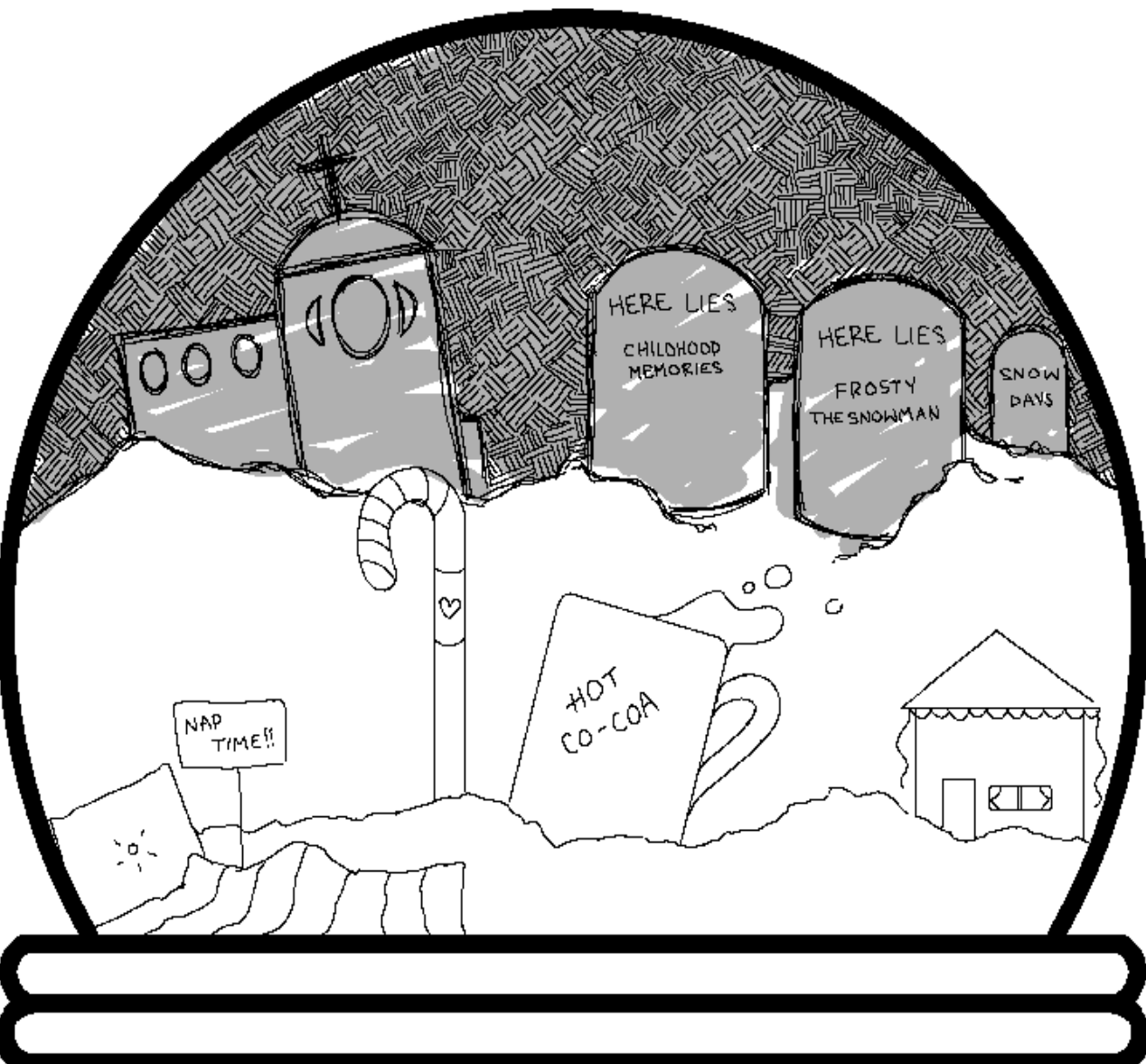




SNOWDAYS NEEDED

District kills snow days in favor of inadequate E-learning

Turning off the alarm clock, snuggling deeper into bed, and just feeling the bliss of no expectations. This is what snow days brought to most students, they were a chance to take a mental health day or just get caught up on schoolwork. Omaha Public Schools (OPS) is taking away a childhood staple to replace it with an ineffective remote learning day. Snow days are something every student looks

forward to, getting the robot call and seeing the name of one's district scroll across the bottom of the news channel. Being able to stay up late watching TV or playing video games. It's a universal childhood memory. Now children can expect to wake up and log into classes for an hour starting at 8:40 a.m. Teachers have even gone against this decision, saying how they don't know what they

could teach in an hour and make sure it actually sticks. We understand that they want to utilize our new one to one technology because before we didn't have this opportunity but there are better ways to go about the remote learning snow days if we are forced to have them. For example, Millard Public Schools also do remote learning instead of the normal snow days.

Although instead of forcing students to log into class and stay there for the whole hour, they have their teachers post assignments and be readily available if students need help. This seems more effective than how OPS is doing their remote learning snow days because it still gives the students a chance to have a normal snow day and it's less constructing. OPS needs to reevaluate our new snow days.

Meaningful volunteer opportunities abundant

People constantly look for ways to change their perspective and to grow as a person. Most try mediation or engaging more in their education but the best way to learn more about the world and grow oneself is volunteering. One person on the Orator's staff used to volunteer at a nursing home. They used to go and do activities with them. They would smile ear to ear just because they had someone to talk to and just to have a new person around. The stories they told and all the advice they had given changed their life forever. This wasn't a random person's Ted Talk telling them to be productive and to take chances, it was someone right in front of them telling them their

regrets and things they wish they had done. Also most non-profits run off of volunteers, without people giving their time they won't be able to give back into our communities. For example, the Stephen Center, wouldn't be able to function without volunteers. Because these volunteers provide so many services to homeless shelters, they are able to afford to do things like feeding residents, helping set them up with jobs, and eventually help move residents into their own homes. Donating any amount of time into volunteering will not only affect the community by making it better but it will also make the person volunteering better.

PLACES TO VOLUNTEER

HOSPITALS

Volunteering at a hospital like the Children's Hospital gives the opportunities for volunteers to play and interact with the children, work at the gift shop, visit families in the surgery waiting area, and many more opportunities. It's a great way to help a child feel better, especially during the upcoming holiday season.

HOMELESS SHELTERS

Many homeless shelters, like the Stephen Center, would not be able to function if it wasn't for the volunteers. Volunteers help keep homeless shelters fully staffed, provide essential services, and able to provide for all their residents and help residents get back on their feet.

NURSING HOMES

Many nursing homes and senior citizen homes take volunteers and they can help with things like cleaning up after events, keeping the residents company, and many more things. Check with a nearby home to see if they have any volunteering spots available.

PARK CLEANUPS

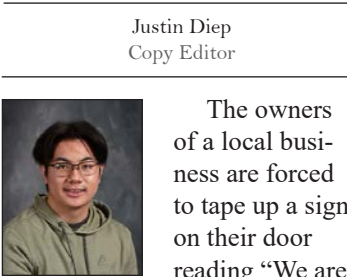
Volunteering at a park to help clean it up not only helps the environment, but it also makes parks a safer and cleaner area for children and their families to come and play and have fun. The Keep Omaha Beautiful litter cleanup program has many opportunities for young volunteers all across Omaha.

Infographic by: Amber Roth



SHOP LOCAL

Supporting local business means more, helps more



The owners of a local business are forced to tape up a sign on their door reading "We are grateful that the community to give us the opportunity to serve you, but we have been forced to shut down." Both local business and large corporations were hit hard and continue to face the struggles of the pandemic. With limited aid

from the government, it is up to the members of the community these local businesses serve to make sure they stay afloat. These businesses are more than just a place to get goods and services. They account for most of the business conducted in this country. According to the Small Business Administration over 99 percent of all businesses are considered small and comprise most of the employment in this country. Buying from local business not only support the employees that work there but they rein-

vest back into the community. According to 10 Reasons to Buy Local Nebraska Food by the University of Nebraska at Lincoln, almost half your money spent at a local business will go back into the community while less than 15 percent of your money spent at a non-local business goes back into the community. Not only non profits benefit but local economies across the state does as well. UNL states "If every household in Nebraska spent an additional \$10 a week on local foods local economic activity would increase by 15

million a month, 160 million a year." Other benefits cited was bringing more jobs into the state especially in the more rural communities. Buying food that is locally sourced is also fresher and has less of a carbon footprint than non-local foods. Food is often picked when it's not ripe and then thrown onto a truck to be driven for thousands of miles before arriving to a supermarket which could be sitting there for days or weeks before it is purchased. While at a farmers' market food does not have to

travel as far so it can be picked once it is ready and ripe, it will only be a few days old when you receive the product. Local businesses are unique to each city. Without them Omaha and every other city would have the exact same big-name chain stores and without the community spending their dollars at these local businesses cities will become just that. These businesses need our help. Supporting these establishments can be as simple as shopping there.

Coping with illness, death difficult especially with COVID-19 restrictions limiting visits, funerals



The hospital smell will forever be something that sticks with me. The overwhelming scent of disinfectant with the occasional smell of flowers trying to overpower all the chemicals and sadness. I've spent many years basically living in a hospital because of my grandma's battle with cancer. When I was younger, I didn't quite understand what happened to my bubbly upbeat grandma; I slowly watched her diminish in

front of my eyes. She started to talk less and sleep more, she never really cracked jokes anymore. All the things we loved to do together she couldn't anymore, I lost my grandma before she even died. Losing my grandmother was the hardest thing I had ever had to overcome; my mom didn't truly know how to help me since she lost her mom and was grieving too. How does one simply just get over the fact they lost their lifelong best friend, the person that would always be there for them and the one who knew how to make a horrible day turn into an amazing one with just a phone call?

The answer is that they don't, everyone tells people grieving that one day it will be easier. While that is true the grief will never leave. I was blessed I got to sit with my grandma and hold her hand. Tell her we would be fine without her, to be able to give her that peace of mind. Unfortunately with this pandemic people aren't able to sit with their loved ones and be with them. They aren't able to sit there and truly be able to start to understand and accept losing their loved ones. Seeing them and understanding it's their time to go. Grief is a hard thing to deal

with especially at a young age. Everyone constantly reassured me "It gets easier with time I promise," or "She is in a better place now," but to me these were always just empty words because it never got easier and I couldn't imagine anywhere better for her to be than beside me. The biggest misconception about losing a love one is that one day people will just forget how their heart aches for their loved one. This isn't true, people will constantly miss them, whether it's because they made their favorite meal or saw their favorite color on a cute shirt. It will hurt for a while but one day the pain will become more

bearable. Don't try to avoid grieving, people need to let the world end and crash around them. It needs to be okay and scream and cry and just let everything out. Let grief become their best friend, listen to what grief has to say because it can teach people so much. It can make people recall memories they could have forgotten, and it can bring people closer together. Grief can be such a powerful thing if people just let grief occur naturally and stop acting like everything is fine. People will mourn the ones they have lost forever and that is okay and normal.